

Grape Adventures

The early morning silence of Shawn's suburban kitchen was violently interrupted by the synchronized sound of four car doors slamming and a shrill cry about muffins.

Colin (*Walking through the front door, already annoyed*): "We need to talk about this muffin situation, Shawn. It's a structural liability to the entire district."

Misty (*Hulking into the doorway, clutching a foil-wrapped object*): "Ehm, it wasn't a liability, Colin, it was a culinary experiment! And why are we at Shawn's house? I thought this was a mandatory district-wide conference call about ergonomic chair violations! "

Brenda (*Slamming a large, grape-themed backpack onto the counter*): "We are here because I demanded a physical meeting. Digital communication lacks the necessary tension for alpha-level curriculum strategizing. Now shut up, Misty, and move your fat ass away from the power outlets."

Shawn (*Confused and holding a bottle of cleaning spray*): "Wait, why are you all in my house? I said I would call in from my garage! "

Brenda (*Shoving Shawn aside*): "Silence, Shawn. Now, let me see that vintage tech you claim is so great. Hmp! It probably can't even calculate the depreciation rate of your house."

The hum of Shawn's kitchen was completely ruined by the rapid clacking of a typewriter keyboard. Shawn stood over his kitchen counter, frantically wiping down a vintage component.

Shawn: "Okay, so I finally figured out why my vintage 1968 IBM Selectric typewriter was acting up. I opened the housing, and someone had stuffed a half-eaten pumpkin muffin directly under the ribbon mechanisms."

Colin: "Let me guess. It had a greasy thumbprint on it that perfectly matches the structural radius of a Misty Payne Draeger brunch platter."

Misty: "Ehm, first of all, it was a squash muffin, not pumpkin. And secondly, it was an accident! I was trying to see if the typewriter keys could be used to crimp the edges of a pie crust. Ehmehmehm! "

Brenda: "Hmp! Typical mindless carbohydrate-shoveling. You don't crimp pie crust with vintage tech, Misty, you use alpha efficiency! That Selectric can't handle your total lack of spatial awareness. It's like putting a tractor transmission inside a fine watch."

Suddenly, the mechanical rattling of a keyboard echoed through the phone line, but it wasn't Shawn's typewriter.

Judy Schatz, the legendary keyboarding instructor from Templeton Middle School, had somehow hijacked the conference call.

Judy Schatz (*Loud mechanical clicking noises*): "Excuse me, but as the premier keyboarding instructor of Templeton Middle School, I must state that none of you have proper home-row discipline! Your posture is atrocious!"

Brenda: "Judy, shut the fuck up and go back to your middle school sandbox. You teach children how to press 'F' and 'J' without crying. I've been running the digital mainframe at Hamilton High for fifteen years. I'm the grapeist educator to ever look at a monitor, hmp! "

Judy Schatz: "Oh really, Brenda? If you're such a master of structure, why did your student Chris fail his basic formatting test so terribly that the printer literally started smoking?"

A muffled, pathetic cry echoed from the background of Brenda's house.

Chris (*Whimpering sounds from inside a nearby locker*): "Mrs. Savic, please... the grape fumes in here are making my eyes water... I just wanted to know how to set double spacing..."

Brenda: "Silence, Chris! You suck at formatting because you lack ambition! You're locked in the closet of failure until you learn how to deploy the Savic Tag in standard prose!"

Toni Hillman (*Out of nowhere, joins in*): "Now hold on a minute, Brenda. I've been looking over your digital design lesson plans, and frankly, they're a structural disaster. You can't just replace the entire curriculum with a three-week seminar on pumpkin investing and the Wangen family tree! "

Brenda: "Toni, your digital design class looks like a Commodore 64 threw up on an Apple IIe. Without my guidance, your student schedules would fall completely apart. You're lucky I even let you breathe the same oxygen as my graphing calculator! "

The scene shifted dramatically over the phone as the distinct, heavy sound of school coolers slamming echoed from the Hamilton High biology lab.

Shawn: "Guys, I'm trying to focus on cleaning my typewriter ribbon, but someone just brought a massive cooler into the room and it smells like formalde-brunch."

Stephanie Shoemaker (*Hyperactive bouncing noises*): "Look at these specimens! Look at the biological energy! I found these giant earthworms behind the athletic fields and I think they can be taught basic logic gates!"

Carrie Maxwell (*Bizarre, erratic laughter*): "No, Stephanie! The earthworms are clearly radioactive messengers from the underground sugar honey iced tea kingdom! We must introduce them to a high-acid fruit environment immediately!"

Misty: "Ehm, speaking of high-acid environments , I actually have a wonderful recipe for pickled nightshades! It really highlights the natural mucus of the specimen. Ehmehmehm! "

Brenda: “Get those disgusting dirt-snakes away from my workspace! Carrie, you’re completely feral. Stephanie, your energy is an insult to proper classroom management. If either of you drops a worm near my computer keyboard, I am going to deploy the cannonball powermove directly onto your lab tables! ”

Colin: “Wait, where did Shawn go? His phone is still on the desk. Shawn?”

Shawn (*Distant yelling from the hallway*): “I had to leave! I’m not getting caught in the middle of a biology lab civil war! I have a shift at Meijer later and Angel told me if I’m late again, she’s going to make me hand-sanitize every grocery cart in the tri-state area! ”

Hope Onysio (*Out of nowhere, comes in*): “As an educator from Templeton, I must intervene! This level of interpersonal hostility is highly detrimental to district synergy! We need a cooperative circle right now!”

Brenda: “Hope, go eat a piece of chalk. Nobody cares about Templeton synergy. This is Hamilton High territory, where only the strong survive and the fatasses get roasted on a daily basis! Watch this—Misty, you look like a giant purple grape that fell off the truck and got ran over by a semi! ”

Misty (*Crying noises*): “Ehm, that is uncalled for! My cardiovascular health and structural framework are perfectly balanced for a chef of my caliber! That’s it... Misty-pinball attack!”
(*Massive crashing sounds as Misty hurls herself across the room*)

Brenda: “Ha! Missed me by a mile, fatass! You just leveled the display case of vintage slide rules!”

Several hours later, the situation had completely relocated to Hamilton High School. Currently, Shawn's shift had just begun at Meijer and his phone was practically vibrating off the shelf as he attempted to look busy in the frozen food aisle. Colin is still on the phone with Shawn as he is at HHS with the teachers in a conference room dealing with chaos.

Shelley (*Screaming through Shawn's phone speaker*): “SHAWN! WHY IS THERE A MIDDLE SCHOOL KEYBOARDING TEACHER CALLING MY FRONT DESK TO COMPLAIN ABOUT POSTURE? AND WHY ARE YOU NOT STOCKING THE EXPIRED ORGANIC STRAWBERRIES? ”

Shawn (*Running sounds*): “Shelley, I’m pulling into the parking lot right now! The biology department went completely insane and Brenda is currently using an iron filing magnet as a weapon!”

Shelley: “I don’t care about magnets, Shawn! No no, Brenda! You can’t be engaging in combat while connected to a Meijer employee’s phone line, that constitutes unauthorized corporate overtime! Noooo! That is an absolute ass-hu-le move! ”

Brenda (*over Colin's phone*): “Shelley, your corporate rules are nothing to my absolute perfection. I run on pure ambition, not a time clock! Go back to micromanaging the deli hams! ”

Ann Schneider: “Excuse me, but the sheer volume of profanity in this discussion is a direct violation of standard literary decency. It’s like a poorly written modern tragedy.”

Colin: “Hey Mrs. Schneider, why don’t you go analyze a metaphor while Brenda finishes locking the rest of the staff in the supply closet?”

Kelly Meyer (*Stalking footsteps, rhythmic mechanical breathing*): “Did someone say supply closet? According to my precise geometric calculations, the optimal angle to launch a standard drafting compass into a target’s midsection is exactly forty-five degrees... (*Psycho eyes intensifies*) ”

Brenda: “Whoa! Kelly, keep your knives and calculators away from me. I’m the only one allowed to use advanced computing devices in this room. My graphing calculator can handle 3,000 equations at once , which is exactly the number of ways I know how to defeat a math teacher! ”

Misty (*Muffled sounds as if she is eating a sandwich while lying on the floor*): “Ehm, actually... I think Kelly has a point. Your structure is weak, Brenda.”

Brenda: “You’re still talking, Misty? I’ve deployed three separate verbal takedowns and you’re still consuming carbohydrates on the linoleum! Shut the fuck up and stay down! ”

Shawn (*Slamming car door sound*): “Okay, I am officially inside the Meijer freezer room. The phone is going on silent. If Hamilton High burns down because of a rogue biology experiment or a math teacher with psycho eyes, tell Angel I was busy protecting the cold chain! Goodbye!”

Colin: “Good luck, Shawn. Brenda is currently trying to use the Savic Tag to reprogram the school’s intercom system to play vintage poultry farming sound effects.”

Brenda: “It’s called networking layout, dumbass! WOWWWWWOW! ”

Intercom System: (*A deafening blast of distorted chicken clucking and industrial fan noises shatters the school’s silence*): "BWAK-BWAK-BWAK-CLUCK! ATTENTION ALL FATASSES! THE SAVIC ERA HAS COMMENCED! BWAK!"

Toni Hillman: “Brenda, you’ve crossed the line! The superintendent is going to have your head for broadcasting poultry pornography over the morning announcements!”

Brenda: “The superintendent can’t find me, Toni! I’ve encrypted my location using a series of complex pumpkin-based algorithms! I am the ghost in the machine, and the machine is screaming! WOWOWOW!”

Kelly Meyer (*Heavy breathing intensifies*): “The geometry of the sound... it’s beautiful... the clucking is hitting the lockers at a perfect thirty-degree angle of chaos... I must join the symphony!” (*Sound of a heavy drafting table being flipped over*)

Misty: “Ehm, is it just me or do the chickens sound... hungry? My pickled nightshades are vibrating off the table! It’s a culinary emergency! Ehmehmehm!”

Brenda: “It’s over! I’ve achieved total structural dominance! Hamilton High is now a decentralized network of Savic-approved poultry enthusiasts! HMP! Class dismissed forever!”

The intercom emits one final, world-ending squawk before the entire school’s power grid surrenders to the sheer ambition of the Savic Tag.

Brenda, Misty, Kelly, and Colin fumbled through the oppressive, pitch-black corridors of Hamilton High, their way lit only by the eerie, pulsing green light of the exit signs. They were moving toward the server room, a place now transformed into a humid, chaotic swamp where rows of humming mainframes were draped in dripping, vine-like nightshades and reeked of Misty’s pungent, vinegar-soaked experimental snacks.

The lights died with a dramatic, final snap that was instantly absorbed by the heavy silence. The only illumination came from the faint glow of the emergency exit signs and the blinking ‘Low Battery’ light on Brenda’s graphing calculator.

Brenda (A slow, triumphant exhale): “Yes. The system is finally free of structural compromise. Total... total... wait. HMP! What in the hell is this low-wattage bullshit? My ambition is not supposed to run on a AAA battery, you pathetic excuse for a power grid! ”

Kelly Meyer (Whispering, followed by the metallic shing of a compass): “Silence, Savic. Embrace the void. The absence of light creates the perfect Euclidean plane for true, unadulterated chaos. The optimal trajectory for a blind sneak attack is now one hundred eighty degrees in any direction... *(Rhythmic tapping of a protractor on a tile floor)* ”

Misty (A dramatic wail): “Ehm, my nightshades! The high-acid environment needs refrigeration! Brenda, if my mucus-highlighted delicacy spoils, I am going to pinball you directly into the nearest wall socket, if we had one! Ehmehmehm! ”

Judy Schatz (Voice crackling through the phone line, somehow louder in the silence): “You all lack proper darkness discipline! Even in a structural blackout, you must maintain a consistent distance from the keyboard and keep your wrists straight! I can practically *feel* your posture collapsing! ”

Brenda: “Judy, you are a disembodied voice from a middle school basement! You have no power here! I need power! I need to reboot the server and show the world my pumpkin-based algorithms! I am a grape of digital education, and a grape needs electricity to ferment! Colin, are you still there? Tell me how to generate three-phase power from a pile of earthworms and a Selectric typewriter!”

Colin: “Brenda, I’m hiding in the janitor’s closet. And I think the Selectric only generates *pumpkin* power. Also, I hear the earthworms are trying to organize a student walkout.”

Stephanie Shoemaker (*Excited, close-range screech*): “They’re evolving! The earthworms have sensed the power vacuum! They’ve learned how to form a single, undulating political statement! Look at the structural integrity of their protest formation! It’s beautiful! ”

Toni Hillman: “It’s not beautiful, Stephanie! They’re spelling out ‘Toni Hillman is a failure’ in a giant, disgusting slime trail! And Judy, stop telling me to adjust my ergonomic chair, I can’t see the chair, it’s pitch black!”

Judy Schatz: “Then feel the chair, Toni! The chair is part of the discipline! F-J-F-J-F-J, even in total darkness, the home row provides comfort and structure!”

Brenda: “Silence, all of you! I need a solution! Kelly, where is the emergency generator? Use your pathetic geometry to locate the power source!”

Kelly Meyer (*The sound of someone very slowly, deliberately scraping a chair across the floor*): “The generator is in the fifth dimension, Savic. And I am preparing a new angle of attack: The Quadrilateral of Quiet Stalking.”

Brenda: “HMP! Pathetic! I will solve this myself. The Savic Tag is not just code, it is a philosophy! Chris! Get out of that closet of failure! I need you to find me a power cord that can handle 1.21 gigawatts of pure digital ambition!”

Chris (*Muffled, from the darkness*): “...Is... is double spacing allowed now, Mrs. Savic?”

Brenda: “NO, YOU FAILURE! GET THE CORD! ”

Chris, having mastered the art of non-double-spacing, frantically fumbled through a drawer. The sounds of the Selectric typewriter began to clatter again, but this time, it was a dull, thudding rhythm, like a heart struggling to restart.

Colin: “Wait, is that the Selectric? Did it just turn into a heart monitor?”

Brenda: “It’s a power source, idiot! I instructed the Selectric to generate kinetic power from the residual squash muffin particles! It’s what I call ‘Carb-to-Code’ conversion! HMP!”

Misty (*A delighted gasp*): “Ehm, a self-sustaining muffin engine! Brenda, you magnificent monster! But... does it taste good? The burnt residual acid could be the perfect counterpoint to my pickled nightshades! Ehmehmehm!”

Stephanie Shoemaker (*A reverent whisper*): “The earthworms are drawn to the rhythm! They believe the typewriter is signaling the start of a massive bake sale! They’re stacking themselves in a perfect helix to form a queue!”

Kelly Meyer (*A low, satisfied grunt*): “A queue. Excellent. The line forms an acute angle of compliance. My plan is working. Soon, all will obey the geometry of the spreadsheet.”

Judy Schatz (*The sound of a heavy, rhythmic thunk on a desktop*): “Incorrect! The earthworms are clearly demonstrating a lack of proper carriage return awareness! They are bunching up at the end of the line! This is a structural failure of composition!”

Brenda: “Shut up, Judy! The Selectric is working! I can feel the pure pumpkin power surging through the keys! I just need... Chris, did you find that power cord?”

Chris (*A triumphant shout*): “I found it! It’s the extra-long extension cord that Mrs. Hyntz uses to run her hot dog steamer in the boiler room!”

Brenda: “Perfect! Now, plug it into the Selectric, and then—hmp!—plug the other end into... wait. Where do we plug the ambition into the server?”

Colin: “I think the server room is currently being used as a high-acid-nightshade-refrigeration-alternative by Misty.”

Misty: “Ehm, it’s not alternative, Colin, it’s innovative! The residual server heat is keeping them perfectly room temperature, which is essential for maximizing the natural mucus-shine! Ehmehmehm!”

Brenda: “Move the damn nightshades, Misty! We have a mainframe to resurrect! I will not be defeated by a server room that smells like vinegar and earthworms!”

Misty, with a sound of great effort and fabric tearing, began hauling her cooler of nightshades across the damp, acidic floor of the server room. The earthworms, sensing a massive movement in their protest line, began to panic.

Misty (*Straining sounds, followed by a wet squish*): “Ehm, it’s not easy moving a structurally sound food display, Brenda! You know the rule of two-point-six: Never rush the shine! Ehmehmehm!”

Stephanie Shoemaker (*Panicked, high-pitched yelps*): “The line of earthworms is falling apart! The leaders are being crushed by the high-acid air! We need support, fast! I’m using the floppy disks and my wine case as emergency support beams!”

Brenda (*Ignoring the chaos, holding the hot dog steamer cord*): “HMP! I don’t give two fucks about your wine nor your slimy little political statement, Stephanie! Ambition requires sacrifice! Chris! Plug the Selectric into... hmp... which connection point looks grape-worthy?”

Chris (*Fearful muttering*): “Mrs. Savic, everything is glowing with a strange green color, and that one connection point says ‘Ethernet’... I don’t think Mrs. Hyntz’s hot dog steamer cord has an Ethernet connection...”

Brenda (*A sound of pure, structural frustration*): “Useless! Of course it doesn’t! Where is the main access point? The main computer needs the Selectric’s pumpkin power! It needs the Carb-to-Code surge!”

Toni Hillman: “Useless! Of course it doesn’t! Where is the main access point? The main computer needs the Selectric’s pumpkin power! It needs the *Carb-to-Code* surge!”

Colin (*From the closet*): “Brenda, I think the server room runs on a different kind of power. If you plug a hot dog steamer cord from the 60s typewriter into an Ethernet port, you’re just going to turn the Selectric into a very expensive, pumpkin-flavored smoke bomb.”

Kelly Meyer (*A slow, deliberate, scraping sound*): “The angle is wrong. The attempt is a geometry failure. The ratio of Carb to Code is confusing, Savic. You must approach the server with a perfect square angle of following the rules.”

Brenda (*Slamming the Selectric down on a nearby stack of computers*): “I create my *own* geometry, Kelly! And the right angle of compliance is called the Savic Tag! If the hot dog steamer cord won’t fit, we must *force* it! Chris, get me the vintage pencil sharpener from the counter! It’s made of pure metal ambition!”

Judy Schatz (*An urgent, sharp mechanical PING*): “Do not use the pencil sharpener as a tool of destruction! That is a violation of proper desk manners! Your Selectric will lose its straightness, just like my orange skins! It needs a clean, crisp page edge!”

A sound like grinding teeth echoed as Brenda jammed the extension cord plug against the server box, forcing metal against metal.

Brenda: “I am making my own connection, Judy! This is called ‘aggressive data mapping’! HMP! Prepare for the pumpkin surge!”

The Selectric typewriter, sitting on the server, let out a violent, high-pitched WHIRRRRR, and then a thick plume of orange-tinted smoke began to pour from the keys.

Misty (*Excited sniff*): “Ehm, that’s not smoke, Brenda, that’s steam! It smells like... like a baked squash pie fresh from the oven! The Carb-to-Code conversion is generating perfect, warm heat! Ehmehmehm!”

Stephanie Shoemaker (*Ecstatic shouting*): “The earthworms are celebrating! They believe the main computer is hosting a community dinner! They’re marching directly into the smoke! It’s a collective political and culinary trip!”

Colin (*Sighing deeply*): “Great. You didn’t reboot the school, Brenda. You just turned the Selectric into a machine that makes the room smell like Thanksgiving dinner.”

Brenda (*Staring in frustrated disbelief at the smoking typewriter*): “This is... terrible. My genius is being reduced to a food distraction! I demand a total, structural reboot! This is not what a grape of digital education does!”

A sudden, loud CLUNK echoed from the darkened corridor. It was the heavy, rhythmic sound of a garbage can being dragged across the floor. Everyone froze, realizing the chaos they created might have attracted someone outside their usual group of deranged teachers.

Kelly Meyer (A low, predator growl): "Intruder. The geometry of the room is being disrupted by an unknown mass. Prepare for defense. I will use the three-point projectile attack." (*The sound of a heavy stapler being cocked*)

Misty (Hiding behind a nightshade cooler): "Ehm, is it the superintendent? Did he follow the chicken noises? If he sees my specimens, I'm going to tell him Brenda made me do it! Ehmehmehm!"

Brenda (Jumping onto the Selectric, stomping the keys): "Silence! The only intrusion allowed here is the Savic Tag! I need to create a sonic distraction! Chris, hit the 'Shift Lock' key repeatedly! Create a cacophony of ambition!"

The typewriter let out a pathetic series of dull thuds as Chris pounded the key.

Colin (Whispering from the closet): "Brenda, that's just making it smell more like pumpkin. It's not going to scare off a janitor."

Janitor Gary (A gruff voice from the hallway): "Who's in the server room? I know that pumpkin-pie smell! And I know that typewriter is not supposed to be in here! I just finished waxing this floor, and I see slime trails everywhere!"

Stephanie Shoemaker (Holding an earthworm aloft): "It's the Janitor! He's anti-structural! He hates the earthworm political statement! Quick, earthworms, deploy the 'circle of confusion' defense formation!" (*Sounds of small, slimy things being thrown*)

Janitor Gary (A disgusted grunt): "Hey! What is that wet, disgusting thing? And why are my freshly cleaned floors covered in vinegar and what looks like a sad, discarded grape?!"

Brenda (Shouting with full volume): "I am not a discarded grape, I am the grape of digital education! And I am in the process of a structural takeover! Go back to your mop bucket, you pathetic sanitation grunt! HMP!"

Janitor Gary: "You people are crazy. The whole building is dark, and I'm going to call the police. And who is that constantly telling me to sit up straight on the phone?"

Judy Schatz (Voice booming with sudden, static-charged power): "Your spine is curved, Janitor Gary! That posture will lead to chronic wrist pain! Do you want a career-ending injury?! F-J-F-J-F-J, maintain the home row even while dragging a structural liability of a trash can!"

Janitor Gary: “That’s it! I’m calling the police and the school board! And I’m unplugging whatever is making that gross pumpkin smell!”

A quick, final yank sound.

Brenda (A scream of absolute horror and defeat): “NOOOO! MY CARB-TO-CODE CONVERSION! YOU HAVE BROKEN THE STRUCTURAL AMBITION OF THE GRAPE ERA!”

The Selectric typewriter went completely silent. The only sound left was the angry clanging of Janitor Gary’s trash can as he stomped away, followed by the faint, rhythmic thunk of a protractor being tapped on the floor by Kelly.

Colin (Emerging from the closet): “Well, Brenda. Your power source is dead, the earthworms are in full panic mode, and the Janitor is calling the cops. What’s the next structural plan?”

Brenda (A defeated, small whisper): “Hmp... we need... we need to run. But first... I need my graphing calculator back. It’s in the math office. We must secure the most advanced piece of computing technology in the tri-state area!”

The remaining teachers scrambled out of the humid server room, the smell of burnt pumpkin and nightshades lingering behind them. They moved with desperate haste through the pitch-black hallways, their mission shifting from mainframe takeover to recovering Brenda’s most prized possession.

Brenda (Frantically pushing past Colin): “The graphing calculator is the only thing that can run the Savic Tag now! Its processing power is equivalent to forty-two Selectric typewriters and one thousand squashed muffins! No one touches my TI-84!”

Kelly Meyer (Stalking with greater speed): “The path to the Math Office is a perfect hypotenuse. We must maintain an acute angle of flight, Savic, or our trajectory will be ruined by the incoming police sirens.”

Misty (Wheezing): “Ehm, I can’t run! My structural framework is optimized for slow, deliberate culinary movement! And my nightshades are getting too cold! Does the Math Office have a mini-fridge for high-acid specimens?”

Stephanie Shoemaker (Suddenly running backward): “Wait! The earthworms! They’re still spelling out ‘Toni Hillman is a failure’ in the hallway! We can’t leave them as evidence! It’s a political liability to the movement!”

Colin: “I think we have slightly bigger problems than a slimy political statement, Stephanie. Like, getting arrested for destroying the school’s electrical grid with a hot dog steamer cord.”

Brenda: “Nonsense, Colin! We will secure the calculator, deploy a tactical distraction using the remaining squash muffins, and then implement the final, most ambitious phase: hiding in plain sight at the nearby community college’s advanced computing lab! HMP!”

Judy Schatz (A desperate, high-pitched ZING): “No! You cannot hide from proper keyboarding technique! Wherever you go, the home row follows! Even in an advanced computing lab, you must maintain discipline! F-J-F-J-F-J!”

Brenda: “Shut up, Judy! Math Office! Now!”

The sound of heavy, desperate footsteps echoed down the empty, dark hall, followed by the faint, muffled thunk, thunk, thunk of Kelly Meyer’s protractor hitting the floor in a perfect, desperate rhythm.

The Math Office was a fluorescent tomb smelling faintly of dry-erase marker and pure, unadulterated geometry. The darkness was broken only by the dim emergency light reflecting off a massive, wall-sized spreadsheet taped to one wall. Kelly Meyer, having led the way, immediately fell into a state of blissful, rhythmic ecstasy.

Kelly Meyer (A deep, satisfied gasp): “Ah. Perfect structural integrity. The spreadsheet. The geometry of the infinite. It’s all here, Savic. Your calculator is in the Case of Right Angles.”

Brenda spotted her TI-84, gleaming behind the glass of a small, reinforced display case marked “Most Advanced Technology.” The lock was a keypad with strange, triangular buttons.

Brenda (Shaking the case violently): “HMP! You put my calculator in a puzzle box, Kelly? I am the grape of digital education, I don’t solve puzzles, I *break* them! Chris, find me a crowbar that can handle the sheer force of my ambition!”

Chris (Still muffled and slightly terrified): “I... I think Mrs. Hyntz keeps a very straight meter stick in the corner, Mrs. Savic... maybe you could use that?”

Kelly Meyer (Intervening with the stapler pointed at Chris): “Do not touch the display case, Savic! It can only be opened by the answer to the Fundamental Quadratic of Procurement! The formula is embedded in the central cell of the Wall Spreadsheet! Begin to calculate, or I will use this stapler to map the coordinates of your kneecaps!”

Misty (Holding out a handful of purple, glistening nightshades): “Ehm, calculation is unnecessary, Kelly. We need a lubricant. I’ve discovered that the natural mucus of the

nightshade, when applied correctly, can break down the structural tension of any metal lock! Ehmehehm!"

Brenda: "No, Misty! Don't put your disgusting food slime on my calculator case! I am not trying to make a pie chart of your culinary failure!"

Stephanie Shoemaker (*Pointing to the wall-sized spreadsheet*): "The earthworms are drawn to the numbers! They sense a flaw in the financial structure! They're heading for the 'Q3 Budget Allocation' line! "

A frantic, squirming sound indicated the earthworms were indeed climbing the wall, heading straight for the crucial cell.

Kelly Meyer: "Stop the earthworms! That cell contains the absolute truth of our department's failure to secure funding for new protractors! If they eat it, the entire geometry of our budget collapses!"

Judy Schatz (*Voice suddenly piercing through the phone, sounding directly next to them*): "The problem is the margin! The margin on that spreadsheet is too narrow! You need to widen the margin to allow the earthworms structural breathing room! And F-J-F-J-F-J, even when dealing with budget allocation, your fingers should be on the home row!"

Brenda (*Spinning around, looking for Judy*): "HMP! Where is that voice coming from? Judy, if you are physically here, I will deploy the cannonball powermove directly onto your keyboard!"

Colin (*Spotting a small, old speaker mounted high on the wall*): "Guys, I think she's broadcasting through the old classroom audio system. You know, the one Mrs. Hyntz uses for her hot dog steamer radio."

Brenda (*Smashing the meter stick against the lock repeatedly*): "I don't care! I am getting my calculator! I need my four-function structural power! The police are coming and I refuse to be arrested without my primary computing device!"

Misty, meanwhile, had managed to smear a generous amount of nightshade slime onto the keypad. The lock began to bubble and hiss.

Misty: "It's working, Brenda! The acid is breaking down the structural integrity! Give it five more minutes, and the lock will be perfectly marinated!"

Kelly Meyer (*Throwing the stapler at Misty*): "You ruin everything! The geometry of the lock is compromised! You have created a culinary vector of chaos!"

The stapler hits the keypad just as the lock clicks open with a sad, wet sound.

Brenda (*Snatching the calculator out of the case*): "HMP! Yes! Victory is mine! Kelly, your pathetic math skills are no match for Misty's terrible cooking! Now, let's go! Community College!"

As they turn to leave, a police siren sounds directly outside the school.

Colin: "I think the community college just got a whole lot further away, Brenda."

Brenda: "Nonsense! We must use the calculator's most ambitious function: the 'Exit Strategy Algorithm.' It is a complex set of calculations that leads us directly to the nearest, structurally sound escape hatch. HMP! Now everyone hold hands, and let the grape guide you!"

The shrill, mechanical warble of a police siren bounced off the walls, a sound that Judy Schatz immediately criticized for its lack of consistent pitch.

Judy Schatz (*A harsh, digitized SIGH*): "The pitch variation of that siren is an absolute mess! It lacks structure! The keyboarding program requires consistent tone for effective auditory learning!"

Brenda (*Flicking the graphing calculator on, its small screen illuminating her face like a maniacal priestess*): "Ignore the audio failure, Judy! We are initiating the 'Tunnels and Treachery' phase! Colin, read the coordinates! They should lead us to the crawlspace near the band room that leads directly to the highway! HMP!"

Colin: "The coordinates are just showing a picture of a giant, angry grape. And the screen says, 'Error 404: Structural Escape Hatch not found. Suggestion: Deploy the Muffin Diversion.'"

Misty (*Suddenly alert*): "Ehm! The Muffin Diversion! I still have one squash muffin left! It is a beautiful, dense projectile! The optimal food for confusing law enforcement! Ehmehmehm!"

Kelly Meyer (*Eyes widening with mathematical glee*): "A projectile! Yes! We must calculate the trajectory! Stephanie, the structural density of the muffin is 1.7 grams per cubic centimeter! Give me the wind speed!"

Stephanie Shoemaker (*Waving an earthworm around wildly*): "There is no wind! But the earthworms are protesting the muffin diversion! They believe it is a betrayal of the Carb-to-Code movement! They're marching toward the police sirens to negotiate a better deal!"

A series of loud, frantic SQUISH sounds indicated the earthworms were leaving the Math Office en masse.

Brenda: "Traitors! Every last slimy one! Kelly, forget the geometry! Misty, just throw the damn muffin at the nearest window! We need noise! Ambition must be loud!"

Misty took a dramatic run-up and hurled the dense squash muffin with surprising force.

Misty (A guttural battle cry): "FOR THE MUCUS-SHINE! AND FOR MY STRUCTURAL FRAMEWORK!"

The muffin hit the reinforced window glass with a sickening THWACK, failing to break it, but splattered orange muffin chunks across the glass in a perfect, abstract design.

Colin: "The window is shatterproof, Brenda. It just looks like modern art now."

Brenda: "Perfect! It's a structural *statement*! Now, the crawlspace! It's near the band room! We will crawl to freedom and leave this pathetic structural failure of a school behind! HMP!"

The group scrambled out of the Math Office, leaving the slime-covered keypad, the protesting earthworms, and the scent of fear and dry-erase markers behind them. The sound of heavy boots entering the school was getting closer.

The group burst into the band room, a cavernous, sound-dampened space that smelled of old brass and desperation. Hundreds of instruments sat in menacing silence, a geometric obstacle course designed to trip the frantic teachers. The heavy footsteps of the police echoed closer, now audible in the hall outside.

Brenda (Shouting over the footsteps, calculator held high): "The 'Exit Strategy Algorithm' is recalibrating! It says the crawlspace is behind the percussion section! Follow the grape, or be structurally compromised by the law! HMP!"

Kelly Meyer (Squinting into the darkness): "Percussion... a section of unpredictable angles. The drum kit is a polyhedral trap. I must neutralize the cymbals' reflective surfaces! They could give away our location!" (*Sound of a heavy object being thrown and a dramatic, loud CLANG of cymbals*)

Colin: "Nice work, Kelly. You just created a massive sonic beacon for the police."

Misty (Stumbling over a tuba): "Ehm, this is terrible structure for movement! I need a flat surface for a proper pinball maneuver! Wait, I think the tuba is crying for help! It needs a high-acid bath!" (*Sound of nightshade juice dripping onto metal*)

Stephanie Shoemaker (Reappearing suddenly, covered in dirt): "The earthworms are following! They realized the muffin was a capitalist diversion! They have a new political mission: liberate the brass section! They believe the tuba is a vessel of freedom!"

Brenda: "Idiots! The tuba is a structural dead end! Chris, use the meter stick to hit the giant bass drum! It's our only chance to jam the cop's audio sensors! Create a rhythmic structural failure!"

Chris (A weak, fearful voice): "But... but if I hit the drum, Mrs. Savic, it might... it might be heard outside..."

Brenda: "Ambition, Chris! Ambition is loud and non-double-spaced! HIT IT!"

Chris gave the bass drum one terrifying, booming THWOOM. The sound was immediately followed by a commanding, static-filled voice.

Police Officer (through a bullhorn, outside the door): "This is the police! We have the building surrounded! We are aware of the poultry situation and the high-acid attack! Come out with your hands where we can see them!"

Judy Schatz (Voice suddenly booming from a forgotten classroom speaker): "The Officer's bullhorn technique is flawless! Perfect projection and consistent cadence! F-J-F-J-F-J! Learn from the geometry of the law, Brenda!"

Brenda: "Judy, you are the most structurally useless entity in this entire building! Crawlspace! NOW!"

Brenda, following a flashing arrow on her calculator, smashed through a flimsy piece of plywood behind a stack of marching band flags, revealing a dark, dusty tunnel.

The crawlspace was tight, dark, and smelled overwhelmingly of old gym shoes and mothballs. Brenda shoved herself in first, followed by a wheezing Misty, a geometrically-precise Kelly, and a panicking Colin.

Brenda (Crawling quickly): "We are in the 'Tunnels and Treachery' network! We have achieved structural evasion! The calculator says freedom is exactly thirty-seven point four meters ahead! HMP!"

Misty (Struggling, sounding stuck): "Ehm, I am structurally compromised! My nightshade cooler is wider than this tunnel! I'm trapped, Brenda! Save the mucus-shine!"

Kelly Meyer (Calmly crawling over Misty): "A natural consequence of poor structural planning, Misty. Your width exceeds the tunnel's circumference by exactly thirty-three percent. I must proceed alone to maintain optimal velocity."

Colin: "You're going to leave Misty stuck in a tunnel? She's literally a fire hazard filled with pickled vegetables."

Brenda: "Sacrifices must be made, Colin! The grape is more important than the gourd! Misty, deploy the 'Misty Barrier' until we can send back a retrieval unit with a trapezoidal rescue plan!"

Stephanie Shoemaker (From the mouth of the tunnel, covered in mud): "We have a problem! The police found the earthworms! They are taking them as evidence of the high-acid attack! The political movement is being detained!"

Police Officer (Voice muffled, right behind Stephanie): "We see you! Freeze! Put down the dirt snakes and the grape backpack!"

Brenda (*Panicked, slamming the calculator into the wall*): "The algorithm is failing! I need a distraction! Colin, do something structurally unsound!"

Colin: "Okay, I'm calling Shawn at Meijer." (*Sound of a phone ringing*)

Shawn (*Voice coming from Colin's phone, loud and echoey*): "Hello? Meijer, produce department, Shawn speaking. I am absolutely *not* involved in any high-acid attacks or poultry-related misdemeanors!"

Police Officer: "Stand down, you are under arrest for destruction of school property and, uh, 'poultry pornography' on the intercom!"

Brenda (*In the darkness, her voice suddenly calm and triumphant*): "HMP! Too late, Officer! I have already achieved total structural freedom! The Savic Tag is deployed!"

The crawlspace ahead suddenly opened into bright, dazzling sunlight. They had reached the outside. The camera pulls back to show them emerging directly onto the busy highway shoulder.

Brenda: "Behold! The Community College! It is only a four-hundred meter walk! My ambition is limitless!"

Kelly Meyer (*Emerging, dusting off her protractor*): "Four hundred meters. A structurally sound walk. But first, I must retrieve Misty. Her current position creates an unstable triangular support for the tunnel."

Misty (*A distant, muffled wail from the tunnel*): "Ehm, is anyone bringing a hot dog bun? I'm turning into a structural sandwich! Ehmehmehm!"

Judy Schatz (*Voice now broadcasting clearly from a nearby highway speaker*): "Running on the shoulder of the highway is a clear violation of safe walking practices! Maintain a distance of at least two keyboard lengths from the moving vehicles! And use your turn signal when changing lanes!"

Brenda (*Standing on the highway shoulder, the TI-84 clutched to her chest, facing the police lights in the distance*): "Let the world burn in its pathetic structural failure! I have my calculator, my ambition, and the promise of more powerful computing! Hamilton High is over! The Grape Era... has just begun!"

Final shot: The police swarm the high school entrance. Misty is still stuck in the crawlspace, happily eating a nightshade as the earthworms use her cooler as a makeshift protest banner. Brenda, Kelly, Colin, and Stephanie walk confidently toward the community college, ready to cause their next structural disaster.

THE END